Article

Microsoft Certification QuickStart Guide

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Overview

In this article, we are going to talk about Microsoft Certification's importance, benefit, how to prepare, and how to give exam.

Introduction to Certification

Knowledge is power, especially in the current job market. Documentation of your skills enables you to advance your career or help you to start a new one. Getting a certificate proves your commitment to upgrade your skills, gives you the credibility needed for more responsibilities, larger projects, and a higher salary.

Seventy-five percent of managers believe that certifications are important to team performance. Forty-five percent of employees strongly agree that when their employers pay for exams, it provides a strong incentive to stay in their jobs.

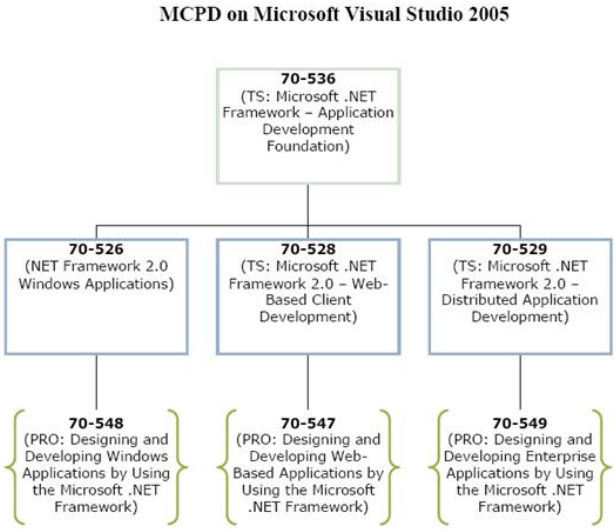
In short, Certification shows that you are a self-learner, and you are keen enough to update your knowledge and it shows your passion about technology. It also validates your skills from Microsoft.

Sounds interesting? Would like to be certified? Here are the steps to get Microsoft certified.

Step 1 : Choose a Path (Which exam should I give?)

Ans: First, you have to choose your path in which you need to give your certification. Currently, there are three main paths available for you.

1. Visual Studio 2005:- If you would like to get your skills certified for **.NET Framework 2.0** then this path is for you.



As shown in diagram 70-536(.NET Framework – Application) is a required for any sub path. Once you pass 70-536 then you can choose any sub path(s) to go for.

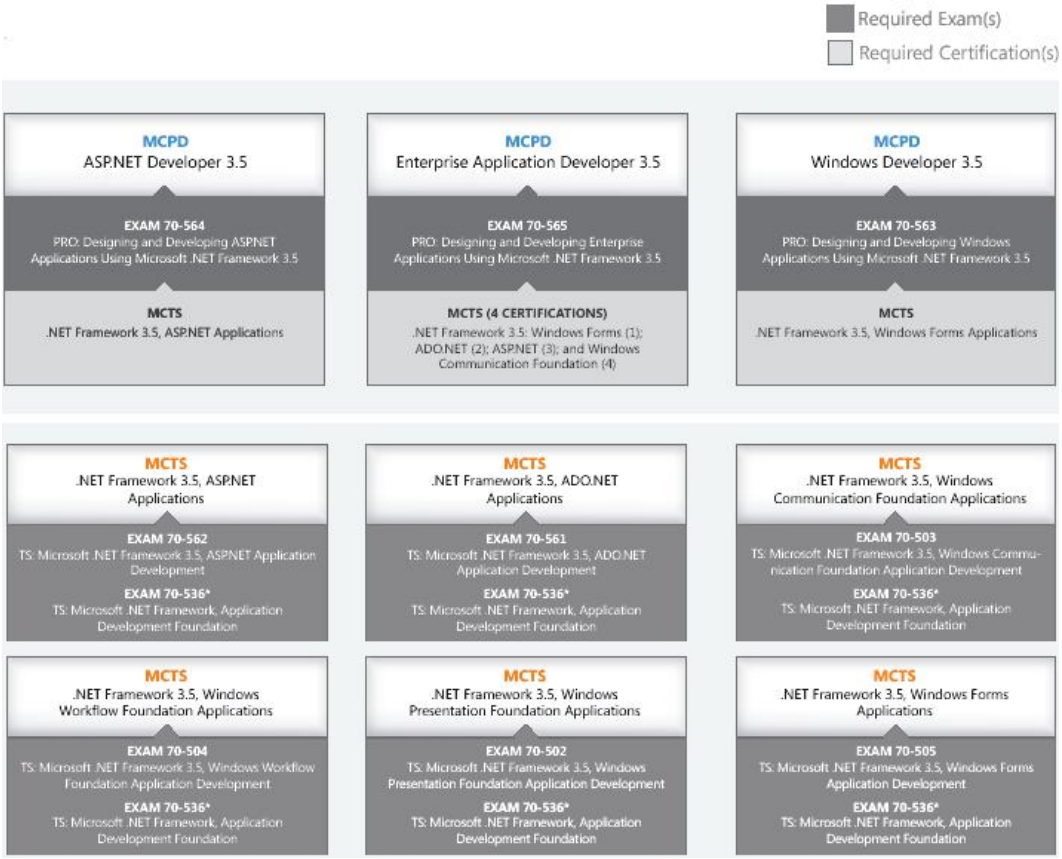
First sub path is for **Windows Developers** – If you would like to get your skills certified for Windows applications you should choose first sub path (70-526, 70-548).

Second sub path is for **Web Developers** – If you would like to get your skills certified for Web applications you should choose second sub path (70-528, 70-547).

Third sub path is for **Distributed application Developers** – – If you would like to get your skills certified for in distributed applications, you should choose third sub path (70-529, 70-549).

Now, you must be thinking why two exams for each sub path? Good question. Let me answer it. When ever you give any first exam from any of these sub paths like **70-526/70-528/70-529** then you will be **MCTS (Microsoft Certified Technology Specialist – In that Field)** e.g. If you clear **70-528** then you will get **MCTS – Web** Certificate. In addition, after that whenever you clear next exam from your sub path then you will be **MCPD (Microsoft Certified Professional Developer)** – In that field e.g. If you clear **70-547** then you will get **MCPD –Web** Certification.

2. Visual Studio 2008:- If you would like to get your skills certified for **.NET Framework 3.5** then this path is for you.



Just a note: 70-536 exam is common for Visual Studio 2005 and Visual Studio 2008 exams.

You can choose any sub path from above given diagram. The certificate pattern will be same as discussed in VS 2005 section.

Upgrade Path from Visual Studio 2005 to Visual Studio 2008

If you have cleared your certifications with **Visual Studio 2005 Path** and you would like to update your certification skills for **Visual Studio 2008** then you have to give update exam for that. E.g. If I have MCPD – Web(70-547) in 2005 and I would like to upgrade it to MCPD – Web 3.5 then I can do it by giving one exam with exam code – 70-567

3. Visual Studio 2010:- If you would like to get your skills certified for **.NET Framework 4.0** then this path is for you.

To Download Path guidance PDF from Microsoft have a look at links given below in Resources section

Step 2 : Start Preparing (How should I start preparing for an exam?)

Ans: Once you have finalized that which exam you would like to give. You can start preparing by reading Microsoft Press Books and they are available for each exam code. You can download soft copy from Web or Purchase hard copy whatever suits you the best!

If you buy a Hard copy of Book then you will get a CD as well. This contains Lab source code and Simulation exams.

Following are few guidelines for reading a book:

- ✓ Read book thoroughly first time (It will be really helpful if you take your notes while reading a book, also at the end of each lesson you will find few questions related to that lesson, try to answer them honestly and don't miss any LAB – Lab contains step by step tutorial for doing any concept practically which really helps you to clear your understanding!).
- ✓ In addition, revise it quickly before giving an exam.
- ✓ Finally, two weeks before your exam date, start downloading "dumps". Dumps are simulation exams, which you can get from Web for each of your exam codes. Note: There are many dumps for each exam code, and it is better to ask someone, who has already prepared for an exam, which are important and which are not. From my experience, "TestKing", "Brain dumps", and "Pass4Sure" dumps are the most useful. You can get 80%-100% questions from dumps in the real exam but I cannot guarantee this!

Step 3 : Go for an exam (Where and how can I take an exam?)

Ans: When you have read book twice, you have given dumps exams. In addition, If you are confident enough that "yes I'm ready for an exam". Then here are the steps to take an exam:

1. Register for exam at your nearest PROMETRIC Center: - You can register for your exam at nearest PROMETRIC Center – Prometric center is certified to take certification exams. You can find your nearest Prometric center by going on this link : http://www.prometric.com/default.htm

2. Visit your Prometric Center. They will be asking for your exam code and you can choose time slot whichever you would like to choose.

3. In addition, each exam costs 50$(2500 RS.) [While registering for an exam check whether any offer going on? – Because Microsoft provides so many offers for certification]. So, be ready with the amount ☺

4. While appearing for an exam keep your ID Proof (Pan Card, Driving license, etc.) with you they may ask you for identification purpose.

5. Format of the exam is as below:
    a. Total Question : 45
    b. Total Minutes : 140
    c. Total Marks : 1000
    d. Passing Marks : 700
    e. No negative marking ☺
    f. MCQ (Multiple Choice Questions).

6. Once you Press "Finish" button. Your PROMETRIC center will get print out of your marks. Keep it with you for your reference.

7. If you have cleared an exam. You can go for a party! ☺

Step 4 : After exam (What will I get after passing my exam?)

Ans: If this was your first exam then after 7/more days you will get mail from Microsoft on your email ID (Which you provided while registering for an exam at PROMETRIC Center) with your **MCP ID**. Using which you can register yourself on MCP Portal.

Following are few things that you will get after clearing an exam:

- ✓ Industry recognition
- ✓ Access to technical and product information directly from Microsoft
- ✓ Discounts on products and services
- ✓ Microsoft paraphernalia like
    - o **Logo**: **-** you can download your Certification logo from your MCP Portal. Which you can put on your resume, blog anywhere.

- **Certificate**: - You can download your Certificate from your MCP Portal. In addition, if you need hard copy from Microsoft then you can order it by paying some nominal charges.

- **Transcript**: - Transcript lists all your certification exams that you can share with employers by URL.

However, the immediate and most important benefits of certification are as follow, it increases in market value, importance of the person, and boost in his / her career meant for software professionals.

FAQ

Can I clear exam using dumps?
Yes, But It will give you certificate not knowledge.

Benefits of Certification?
By earning a Microsoft Certification, you gain relevant skills that employers respect and you get the opportunity to connect with a global community of other certified professionals. The Microsoft Certification Program also provides you with access to valuable Microsoft resources and benefits, such as access to the member Web site, career-building tools, and training. Explore the benefits of certification—and start your journey towards your ideal career.

What do 70-536/70-528/70-547 numbers mean to say?
It is exam code for each exam. Microsoft has given exam code number for each Microsoft exam as 70-536 is for .NET foundation like that. It is good to know the exam number because while buying/downloading a book you can search by exam code, while registering for exam at Prometric center they may ask you exam code.

Is there a negative marking?
No negative marking.

What is passing score?
700 out of 1000

What is MCP portal?
It is your personalized portal where you can download your logo/certificate etc.

What is Exam Fees?
50$(2500 INR). Nevertheless, always some discount offers are available from Microsoft. So, you can ask for that at your prometric center. Also sometime Microsoft offers second shot offers as well – Unluckily, if you cannot clear exam in first shot you can give second shot free.

Still have questions? You can post them at my blog: http://kiranpatils.wordpress.com or drop me a line at klpatil@yahoo.co.in I will be happy to answer them!

Finally, Thanks to my students, friends and blog readers for inspiring me to write an article on this topic. Also, thanks a lot to my friend Nilesh Thakkar and Jude Martin for helping me in proof reading the document and providing their invaluable suggestions!

Happy Certification! ☺

Best of luck!

Resources

Link	Description
http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=P6FQg7EkKNU	See what Microsoft customers say about the Value of Microsoft Technical Certification.
http://www.microsoft.com/showcase/en/us/details/b5f53794-56aa-47e3-98d8-0d35b379060b	The many benefits of Microsoft Certification, as articulated by real Microsoft Certified Professionals (MCPs), who share their own certification experience, and the positive impact that it has had on their careers.
http://www.microsoft.com/learning/en/us/certification/cert-get-started.aspx	Get Started FAQ
http://download.microsoft.com/download/B/6/6/B66B006F-50AB-493E-BEBE-FD3B1BF548F6/VisualStudio2008_CertPath.pdf	VS 2008 Certification Path
http://download.microsoft.com/download/B/D/D/BDD81000-E7E6-4B7A-A213-8579369FB0AF/VisualStudio2010_CertPath.pdf	VS 2010 Certification Path
http://kiranpatils.wordpress.com/2009/06/27/new-milestone-mcts-web70-528/ http://kiranpatils.wordpress.com/2010/01/01/milestone-mcpd-exam-cleared/	Articles by me on Microsoft Certification